

we will not quantify the emission cuts that will hinder our development plans," says BJP leader Yashwant Sinha. The CPI(M) argues that the leading carbon-spewing nations should first come out with domestic legislations. Both the parties may end up opposing the bill if the Government pushes it in the next session. "Unless world opinion is consolidated, India should not move forward with any domestic legislation. The Congress wants to impose its opinion on other parties," says V. Maitreyan, AIADMK MP and former chairman of the Parliamentary Committee on Environment.

The Environment Ministry has

pressurise the developed nations to go for more concessions. The UPA insists that it is only setting indicative targets and claims that it would give its negotiators enough elbow room in future. But the BJP wonders that if the Government is setting only indicative targets, why should it hurry into a legislative route? "Why should we need a legislation which is of advisory nature?" says Sinha.

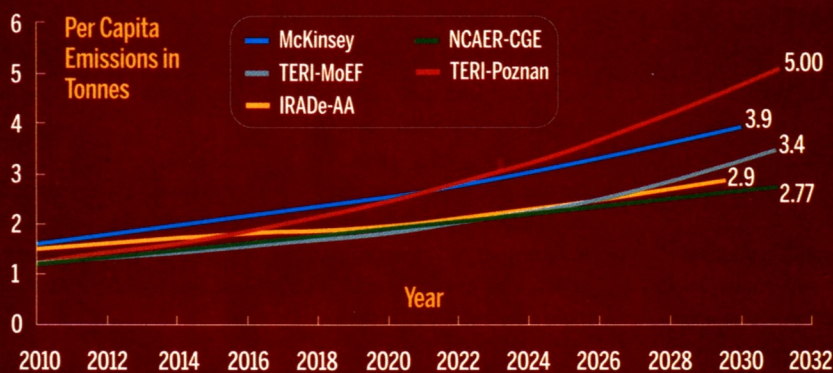
Meanwhile, environmental activists argue that the recent climate extremes witnessed in the country are a wake-up call for India to act on its climate change initiatives. "The shift in India's policy does not need to be

cycles, causing collateral damage.

The Government's musings about the domestic legislation at international fora without proper domestic consultation may complicate India's position internationally. At global high tables, the Government says that any reduction in targets would deny electricity to Indian villagers. It has accused the West of putting their "lifestyle emissions" before its "survival emissions". But as it ventures into any important policy formulations, none of the vulnerable communities, major political parties, civil society groups and other stakeholders have been taken into confidence.

Not Just Gas

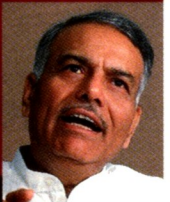
Per capita greenhouse gas emission projections for India from five studies in illustrative scenarios till 2030



Except for TERI-Poznan, all the four studies indicate that India's per capita greenhouse gas emissions in 2030 will be below the 2005 global average of 4.22 tonnes.

"Why should we need a climate legislation which is of advisory nature?"

YASHWANT SINHA, BJP Leader



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V. MAITREYAN, AIADMK MP



Source: Ministry of Environment and Forests

prepared a concept note according to which a mandatory fuel efficiency target would come into effect in 2011, and a more energy-efficient building code in 2012. A national body under the prime minister will be set up to monitor the targets. Though many of these efforts already exist in earlier legislations as aspirational targets, the UPA has walked into a political minefield by choosing a fresh legislative route to quantify the emissions. The Government argues that by setting targets, it would dent the contention that India is unwilling to take action on climate change and

seen as succumbing to pressure from the rich countries. An economy without commitment to the environment and ethics will not be successful in the long run," says John Samuel, international director, ActionAid. Going by various projections, countries like India and China are expected to suffer disproportionately because of how climate change is affecting different geographic regions. While warmer Himalayas would make the Ganges and Indus more seasonal rather than year-round rivers, the Indian monsoon will become more intense, often out of sync with crop

"There should be proper debate before announcing such moves internationally. The Government should engage the country before taking crucial steps," says M.J. Vijayan of the India Climate Justice Alliance.

India needs to bring all of its persuasive and rhetorical skills to achieve an international treaty that will keep in mind its energy needs and make the developed nations to live up to their responsibility. By failing to warm chilly political relations back home, the Government will end up tying its hands locally in a battle it is waging globally. ■